Central European status was a more difficult task. Mostly because of the imagined baggage it brought from its years as part of Yugoslavia, above all the war in Yugoslavia, Slovenia also failed to earn membership in the Višegrad group which it desperately wanted at a certain time (although this was denied later by leftist governments) in order to speed up its approach to the EU and NATO and, above all, to decouple itself from the Balkans. In the end, Slovenia joined the EU at the same time as the Višegrad Four but they got NATO membership a few years earlier.

Most Slovenians had, as a matter of fact, left Central Europe at the end of World War I, when Slovenians, Croats and Serbs living within Austria-Hungary proclaimed the so-called State of the Slovenians, Croats and Serbs. This included modern-day Slovenia, Croatia, Bosnia and Herzegovina and the northern Serbian province of Vojvodina with its sizeable Hungarian population and other ethnic minorities. However, nobody wanted to recognise this state and the Italians, following a secret clause in the London Treaty that rewarded Italy for its change of sides, invaded most of what today is western Slovenia, including the village of Vrhpolje mentioned in the introductory chapter. In these circumstances, the young State of the Slovenians, Croats and Serbs was pressed to merge with the Kingdom of Serbia under the Serbian crown – something that Slovenians, let alone Croats, never really wanted. (Despite their pan-Slavic feelings for the Serbs, both Slovenes and Croats had been appalled by the assassination of the Austrian archduke in Sarajevo in 1914 by a Serbian nationalist.) Serbia and its king were very well aware that former Slav subjects of Austria had little leverage and rushed through the swiftly assembled parliament a Constitution that favoured Serbia. Suddenly, the Slovenians found themselves in the same state with lands and peoples that for centuries had been part of the former Ottoman Empire, and with which they only shared either distant Slavic roots or sometimes not even those. The only Central European Slovenians left were those in Austria, though they too were not rewarded for their loyalty to the new Austrian Republic but became subject of a new wave of Germanisation.

To understand the later conflicts within Yugoslavia, it is therefore important to note that Yugoslavia was not a natural choice for many of the peoples included in it – except for the Serbs, who saw it as an extension of their own kingdom. True, the Yugoslav (meaning ‘south Slav’) kingdom did